were demonstrated during evacuation exercises as well, ranging from Yemen and Nepal to Afghanistan, Ukraine and Sudan.

From 2014, there has also been a strong conviction that India should be more active in shaping the global agenda. Obviously, some issues of particular priority for India itself, like terrorism and tax evasion, did not get the attention they deserved in the councils of the world. There were others like maritime security on which India could make a crucial contribution. In due course, when an important debate like the one on connectivity unfolded, the strong confidence level of the Modi government allowed it to take the lead. When it came to climate challenges, India, till 2014, was widely perceived as a reluctant participant. Since then, it has emerged as a credible champion of both climate action and climate justice by becoming an exemplar on renewables and advocate of resourcing.

There was also a belief that we were mostly responding to the initiatives of others rather than putting forward our own thinking. However, whether it was at the UN, G20 Summits or COP meetings, the flow of ideas turned into more structured proposals, like the ISA and the CDRI. The creativity continues, recent examples being One Sun One World One Grid (OSOWOG), Lifestyle for Environment (LiFE) and the International Year of Millets (2023). To take the agenda forward, there was an openness to explore new partners and collaborations where required. The Quad, the I2U2 and the SCO are relevant examples. As confidence grew in our ability to contribute to global solutions, it took diverse forms, a collective one like the development agenda for Africa as well as a unilateral one like the Vaccine Maitri. By dint of application and imagination, the early thoughts about making our presence felt more strongly have now become reality.

While addressing practical challenges to India’s progress, much thought has also been given to branding India in a manner reflecting the rise of a civilizational state. The truth is that two centuries of colonialism had skewed the global discourse so drastically in favour of the West that the heritage, culture and traditions of the rest of the world were relegated to the sidelines. Part of the responsibility for that predicament also rests with the leadership of developing societies. They subscribed to equating modernity and advancement with emulating the West. For reasons both ideological and political, many of them often ran down their own past.

As a result, the imperative for cultural rebalancing to accompany its economic and political facets has only grown with times. Prime Minister